

Dipterus

DIP-ter-us



- **When** 370 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Scotland, N. America
- **Habitat** Rivers and lakes
- **Length** 14 in (35 cm)

Dipterus was a lungfish and a close relative of modern lungfish (strange fish that can breathe air and hibernate in burrows to survive droughts). A large plate over its gill chamber suggests *Dipterus* relied more on its gills than lungs. It had tough teeth, perhaps to crack shellfish, and bony armor plates on its head.



Osteolepis

OST-ee-oh-LEEP-iss



- **When** 390 million years ago (Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Scotland, Latvia, Lithuania, Estonia
- **Habitat** Shallow lakes
- **Length** 20 in (50 cm)

Large, square scales on its body gave *Osteolepis* its name (meaning “bony scale”). The scales and the skull bones were covered with a glossy substance rather like the enamel of human teeth. It lived in the northern lakes of Scotland in the Devonian Period.



Macropoma

mack-roe-POME-ah



- **When** 70 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** England, Czech Republic
- **Habitat** Oceans
- **Length** 22 in (55 cm)

Macropoma belonged to the family of ancient fish known as coelacanths, which had fleshy fins that they could move in a similar fashion to our arms and legs. Coelacanths were once believed to be an evolutionary link between fish and land animals. However, scientists now think that they were not the direct ancestors of land animals.



LIVING RELATIVE

In 1938, fishermen in South Africa found a strange fish in a shark net and showed it to a local scientist. To everyone's astonishment, it turned out to be a coelacanth (“SEE-la-canth”)—a type of fish thought to have been extinct since the age of dinosaurs. This “living fossil” was the zoological find of the century.

